EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

One Soul, Five Names: What the Soul Really Is

Given Monday 10 March 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6:2-3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 6 (The Soul), Chapters 2 and 3

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 10 March 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Six Views That Saadia Rejects

The sixth essay, on the *nefesh*, follows creation from nothing, HaKadosh Baruch Hu, revelation, free will, and merits and demerits. Of its eight chapters, the first five deal with the essence of the soul, Chapters 6 and 7 with what happens after death, and Chapter 8 with reincarnation. (During March, while sunset is later, the shiur would start later than usual, returning to 6 o'clock once the clocks change.)

Last week, in Chapter 1, Saadia went through six views of the soul and tried to disprove each:

1. The soul is an **accident** (*mikreh*), a by-product of the body, not an intended creation, in five versions: a self-moving number of knowledge, the completion of the body, the four natures, the coordination of the senses, or a by-product of the blood.
2. It is **air**.
3. It is **fire**.
4. It has **two parts** (rational and animal).
5. It is **two kinds of air**.
6. It is **the blood** (Anan, the Karaite leader).

The seventh view, Saadia's own, comes in Chapter 3. First, a short digression in Chapter 2.

Chapter 2: "Who Knows?"

Why did Saadia go into the six wrong views? Because, as he said of creation from nothing in Essay 1 and the essence of God in Essay 2, we are dealing with **something very subtle and deep**. The soul has the same status. That is why there are so many conflicting views.

So too, Shlomo HaMelech praises one who can understand the rational, speaking soul of man:

מי יודע רוח בני האדם העלה היא למעלה, ורוח הבהמה הירדת היא למטה לארץ (Kohelet 3:21)

Who knows the spirit of man that goes upward, and the spirit of the animal that goes down to the earth?

Not a doubt, but an affirmation

Some read the verse as a question: who knows *whether* the human spirit goes up and the animal's goes down? Nobody knows. **Saadia completely negates that reading.** "Who knows" does not express doubt; it

establishes that there is a difference, and praises whoever can grasp it. It is like saying, "Who knows how wise Reuven is? Who knows how hard-working Shimon is?" You are not casting doubt; you are affirming that Reuven is wise and Shimon hard-working.

The wonder is that **two souls in two bodies look identical**, yet are very different. A few verses earlier Kohelet says, **ומותר האדם מן הבהמה אין**, "man has no advantage over the beast" (which we say in Shacharit): we live, die, procreate and eat alike, and **הכל הולך אל מקום אחד**, all go to one place, to dust. So who can discern the difference in their souls?

Do not think Shlomo is asking *whether* there is a difference. "No one wise would say something like this. This goes against logic. Even an ignorant person wouldn't believe there's no difference." We see that humans are more honoured than animals; we make animals work for us and ride on them. The bodies are alike because they are made of the same nature. The question is **who can understand the difference**, like two stones, one ordinary and one a ruby. Both are stones; one is worth millions and one a few pennies. You need to be an expert in jewellery to know why.

The difference applies not only between human and animal souls, but **between human souls too**: some are lofty and some lowly.

Saadia offers a second reading: it is not a question at all but a statement. **Whoever knows, knows**: one who understands will see that one soul is lofty and another lowly.

"That's the end of Chapter 2. We don't have to spend too much time on it."

Chapter 3: Saadia's Seven Points on the Soul

Point 1: The soul is created

Based on Essay 1, **nothing is eternal except God**. Saadia is refuting **Plato**, who held that the soul is co-eternal with God. No matter, no substance, no soul existed before creation. The proof: **ויצר רוח אדם בקרבו**, "He forms the spirit of man within him." "Relatively straightforward."

Point 2: Each soul is created with its own body

When does God create the soul? **Simultaneously with the body**, whether at birth or, "more likely," with the forming of the fetus: "it makes no difference really." *Yotzer ruach adam bekirbo*: He forms it **in** him, together with him.

"Now why is this important? I'll tell you why." Kabbalistic literature, and in truth some Midrashim, are full of the idea that **Adam HaRishon contained all the souls** to be created. The Rabbi recalled the **Ramchal** (from *Da'at Tevunot*, learnt by some of the class): all souls were united in Adam; when he sinned, failing the test of recognising Hashem's unity, there was a splitting up, and all the different souls we have today emerged. The **Ramban** clearly holds that all souls were created at the beginning ("I'm not sure what the Rambam holds"), and there are Gemarot to the effect that there is **a storehouse of souls** from which each soul is placed into a body when it is born.

Saadia rejects all of this. Each soul is individual, created together with its body.

His only source is the same verse, and it can be read either way: "He creates the spirit *in* man" could mean He puts in a soul that already existed. "Neither interpretation is *muchrach*." But Saadia is very clear.

A question: didn't Saadia say last week that when the storehouse of souls is used up, the world to come begins? The Rabbi: "I understand why you think he said that. When I learnt it, I also had that question." He reread the opening of Chapter 1: Hashem separates body and soul until **He has completed the number of**

souls He decides to create; then this world ends, a new world is created, and body and soul are reunited. There is a set number of humans Hashem wants to create, but **no storehouse**. "You're thinking of that because the Gemara says something along those lines. Saadia is rejecting that."

A digression: Chassidic dynasties

The Rabbi digressed "really quickly" to show where the storehouse idea leads. In the Chassidic world, the son inherits his father's leadership. On what basis? Chassidut is about 300 years old, and the dynasty was not there at the very beginning; it developed in a later generation, perhaps 250 years ago. The explanation offered was that a holy Rebbe, through his elevated thoughts at the time of conception, can **draw down a holy soul** from the storehouse. So even if the son does not seem as holy or learned, his soul must be holy. "I've seen with my own eyes Chassidic rabbis leading dynasties, not the big ones, who are ignorant, who are not *talmidei chachamim*. They don't know halachah." Why? Because his father must have drawn down a very holy spark. "None of this is acceptable in Saadia's mind."

Point 3: The soul is a substance purer than the heavenly spheres

The soul's essence is **a pure substance, like the purity of the spheres**. It **receives light**, as the spheres receive light from the stars, but its essence is **purer and more refined** than the spheres, and therefore it is endowed with **intellect and speech**.

- It is a **substance**, not an accident; an intentional creation in every creature.
- It is **like the spheres**: a sphere has no light of its own; its brightness depends on how much light the stars shine on it. So the soul's brightness depends on **a person's intellect, virtues and good deeds**, which illuminate it, or his wicked deeds, which darken it. This is what Saadia taught at the start of Essay 5: every action leaves an impression on the soul. Everyone agrees with this, and the **Ramchal** in *Derech Hashem* elaborates on it at length. The illumination or darkness is not always felt, because the soul is concealed within the body; when it is freed, it shows how much light or darkness it has gathered in its lifetime.
- It is **finer than the spheres**, because for Saadia the spheres have no intellect, reason or speech, and the soul does.

"I can't tell you exactly what it is." The word the Rabbi was looking for: **ethereal**. The soul is an ethereal substance like that of the spheres, "but even more ethereal." He found this view attributed to **John Philoponus**, a Greek-Egyptian philosopher in the Aristotelian tradition, some centuries before Saadia: the soul as a kind of light of the heavenly spheres. "Whether Saadia got it from him or not, I don't know."

The Rambam differs on one point: in the Mishneh Torah (Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah, the Rabbi thought chapter 3) he holds that **the spheres have some kind of intellect**, though not speech. "I don't fully understand it myself. Maybe one day we'll go into it."

Saadia's two proofs

Saadia recalls the four sources of knowledge from his introduction: **sense perception, reason, inference and tradition**. He draws on two of them.

1. **Reason.** When the soul is joined to the body, a person is full of wonders: life, reason, speech. When the soul departs, the body is barren of all of it. So these all stem from the soul. If the soul were an ordinary earthly substance, it could not have such wonders; and since the spheres lack intellect and speech, the soul must be **more refined than the spheres**.
2. **Scripture.** Pure souls shine when they do good, as the spheres shine with the light of the stars: **והמשכלים יזהרו כזהר הרקיע**, "the wise shall shine like the brightness of the firmament" (Daniel). Wicked

souls are like a sphere with no light on it: **ושמים לא זכו בעיניו, אף כי נתעב ונאלח איש שתה כמים עולה**, "the heavens are not pure in His eyes; how much less one who is abominable, who drinks iniquity like water" (Iyov). Scripture would not compare the soul to bright or dim spheres unless they were similar in substance.

"Who knows" again

Saadia returns once more to the verse from Chapter 2, citing **והרוח תשוב אל האלהים אשר נתנה**, "and the spirit returns to God who gave it," from the end of Kohelet. "I don't know why he says this now. I couldn't understand this." The Rabbi's suggestion: having just spoken of bright and dim souls, Saadia reinforces that there **are** different kinds of souls, and that "who knows" affirms the difference rather than questioning it.

Point 4: The soul is intelligent in itself

The soul has intelligence **of its own nature**, not from the body, which has no such function.

Saadia's proof is "something very interesting... apparently this was known even in Saadia's time": **a blind person sees in his dreams**. We dream of what our senses took in during the day. But a blind person has never seen anything, and yet sees things in his dreams. (The Rabbi thought this is supported scientifically today, in what is called haptic perception.) He did not get this from his eyes, so he must get it from the soul.

This also answers the view from last week that the soul is **the coordination of the senses**. "You're doing it the wrong way around." It is not the coordination of the senses that produces the soul; **the soul gives the coordination of the senses**. "It is driving the senses; the senses are not driving the soul." (**Philippe** offered a modern analogy: the relation between a mobile phone and the cloud.)

Point 5: The soul acts only through an instrument

"Straightforward." The soul's functions only manifest through an instrument, an organ: **the body**. The collaboration of body and soul lets the soul's potential become actual.

Point 6: Three faculties, and the names of the soul

Once body and soul are joined, the soul has three faculties:

Faculty	Hebrew	Meaning
Discernment	**כח ההכרה**	Reason, logic
Anger	**כח הכעס**	Not literally anger: **strong emotions**
Desire	**כח התאוה**	The appetitive faculty

This is **Plato's** division of the soul: reason; spirit, which houses anger and the emotions; and appetite, which houses the desire for physical pleasures.

That is why the soul has different names. Not because there are different souls or parts, but because of its different faculties:

Name	Faculty	Verse
נפש	Desire	**כי תאוה נפשך**, "when your *nefesh* desires"
רוח	Emotion	**כל רוחו יוציא כסיל**, "a fool vents all his *ruach*"
נשמה	Intellect	**ונשמת שדי תבינם**, "the *neshamah* of the Almighty gives them understanding"

Saadia adds **two more names**:

חיה, because the soul **lives on** for as long as Hashem wills, eternally;

יחידה, because it is **unique**: there is nothing like it. The Rabbi asked where the soul is called this in a passage connected to Purim. After giving Flora ten seconds, he answered: Tehillim 22, the psalm of Purim, **הצילה מחרב נפשי, מיד כלב יחידתי**, "save my soul from the sword, my *yechidah* from the dog".

One soul, not three: Saadia and the Rambam against the philosophers and the Kabbalists

Plato did not only divide the soul into three faculties; he placed them in **three different parts of the body** (the Rabbi thought brain, heart and liver). Saadia rejects that: **there is one soul with three faculties**.

"It's interesting that the Rambam says exactly the same." In the first of his **Shemonah Perakim**, learnt about a year and a half earlier, the Rambam goes to length to say the philosophers erred in thinking the soul has different parts. **There is one soul with faculties**. The Rambam counts **five**: nutritive, sensory, imaginative, appetitive and rational. The rational and appetitive match Saadia's; the emotions are probably included in another. But on the main point they agree: **one soul, many faculties, hence many names**.

The Kabbalah speaks instead of **five souls**, or five levels, in ascending order: **נפש, רוח, נשמה, חיה, יחידה**.

- Everyone has a *nefesh*; even animals have one, though a different kind.
- Above it a person has *ruach* and *neshamah*.
- The Kabbalists say only **Moshe Rabbeinu** was in touch with the fifth, the *yechidah*; the fourth too is beyond ordinary reach.

The extra soul of Shabbat is a true concept, "but the question is how you understand it." In the Kabbalah one receives the additional *nefesh*, *ruach* and *neshamah* at stages: on Friday night, and again on Shabbat morning, the *nefesh* at **Nishmat**, the *ruach* in the Shacharit Amidah, and the *neshamah* at the **Keter** Kedushah of Musaf, at the word **איה**. "That's why the old Iraqi custom was to elongate *Ayeh*, because they were accepting the *neshamah* of Shabbat." Not the fourth and fifth, because no one can reach them, even on Shabbat.

"If you want to do this, do it in the sense that you are getting in touch with the extra elements." For Saadia, the Rambam and the medieval thinkers, there is one soul whose **faculties are more pronounced on Shabbat**: our desire grows, which is why there is more food and certain physical pleasures are meant to be enjoyed; our intellect is engaged in Torah.

Point 7: The seat of the soul is the heart

This ethereal substance with three faculties **dwells in the heart**. Movement and perception come through the arteries and the chambers of the heart. We know great nerves come from the brain, but for Saadia they are physical channels that need the heart to function. That is why Scripture pairs the heart and the soul: **בכל לבבך ובכל נפשך**.

"Fascinating chapter, no?"

Summary

Chapter 2: understanding the soul is as subtle as creation from nothing and the existence of God, hence the many views. **מי יודע** in Kohelet does not doubt the difference between souls; it **affirms** it and admires whoever can discern it (or: "whoever knows, knows").

Chapter 3, Saadia's seven points:

1. The soul is **created**, not eternal (against Plato).
2. Each soul is created **individually, together with its body**: no storehouse of souls, no splitting of Adam's soul.
3. It is a **substance**, ethereal like the heavenly spheres but **purer**, receiving light from a person's intellect and deeds. Proved from reason and from Scripture (Daniel, Iyov).
4. It is **intelligent in itself**, as shown by the blind man who sees in dreams; the soul drives the senses.
5. It acts only through **the body**, its instrument.
6. It has **three faculties**, desire, emotion and intellect, which give the names **nefesh, ruach, neshamah**; it is also called **chayah** (eternal) and **yechidah** (unique). **Five names for one soul**, as the Rambam also holds, against the philosophers' parts and the Kabbalists' levels.
7. Its seat is **the heart**.

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